groups—is not going uncontested even in the current climate. That is no small feat. But that will be far from sufficient as things stand. One problem in imagining a Myanmar where Buddhism is secure enough to co-exist with other faiths is the lack of an alternative perspective from the main opposition party, the NLD. This is the most disappointing fact about the situation in Myanmar, but perhaps also the area where the international community may find that it has the most leverage to improve the situation of the Rohingyas, and also those of other victimised groups.

There is also dissent from within the Buddhist community against the extremists. A practical example of the potential limits to the 969 Movement's power took place at Lashio, just north of Mandalay, in 2013. While the role of the Buddhist establishment is mostly one of condoning or encouraging persecution, this was an instance where the Buddhist community played a positive role. An outburst of inter-communal violence was triggered when a Muslim man set fire to a Buddhist woman after dousing her with gasoline.[101] The ensuing violence saw one Muslim killed and numerous Muslim businesses and houses burnt to the ground. To escape, local Muslims received help from the local army who took them to a monastery where they were fed,[102] and the monks intervened to protect Muslims from further physical violence.[103] Equally, unlike during similar events in Rakhine, the army and police moved to restore order the day after the riots and arrested twenty-five locals for carrying out acts of violence.

There seems little doubt that the reason why an isolated act of madness resulted in a full blown orgy of intercommunity violence was the environment of interreligious mistrust stoked by the 969 Movement.[104] Nevertheless, the events at Lashio expose many of the contradictions in contemporary Myanmar. Many monks have chosen instead to stress the traditions of peace and tolerance within their religion.[105]

This is one example of the dissent to the 969 Movement and the MaBaTha from within the Buddhist monastic communities. Others have occurred. In 2014 some monks worked with the local Muslim community in Mandalay to defuse tensions and promote inter-faith relations.[106] Near Meikhtila some monks also opened their monastery to offer shelter to Muslims being attacked by supporters of the 969 Movement. Importantly, there is also evidence that this reflects a generational divide, with older monks who took part in the 1988 revolt being more likely to speak out